

COME ON IN PDP chief Mehbooba Mufti welcomes Hurriyat leader Syed Salim Gilani to the party, Sep. 1

ABID BHAT

but the key was the high voter turnout (58.4 per cent) in the recent Lok Sabha election. Such huge public participation was seen after 35 years. Unlike in the past, the election saw more than 2,400 rallies in the five LS constituencies in J&K. "We must accept that the election was held in a free and fair manner," says a Jamaat member who cast his vote for the first time. Many members had queued up outside the booths and even posted photos on social media showing inked fingers. "The boycott policy proved futile. Now we want someone to lead us who can change our future," he says.

The change is everywhere. On Sep. 1, senior separatist leader and a Hurriyat mainstay for three decades, Syed Salim Gilani, switched sides and signed up with Mehbooba Mufti's Peoples Democratic Party, saying he wanted to "serve the people and be part of mainstream politics". "The Hurriyat's politics has limitations," he says. "We cannot solve the issues of the people. By joining the PDP, I'll be able to serve their needs better."

In north Kashmir's Langate constituency, Dr Kalimullah Lone, a PhD in Computer Science from the National Institute of Technology (NIT), feels the same. He is contesting from jailed MP Sheikh Abdul 'Engineer' Rashid's home constituency. The son of influential Jamaat leader Ghulam Qadir Lone, he wants to see Kashmir's youth compete with their counterparts elsewhere in the country. He says his father would have contested if the ban on the Jamaat was revoked. "If they (Jamaat) are a problem," says the 35-year-old, "there are provisions where the group can be given a chance to change."

A senior government official dealing with policy decisions feels the "mainstreaming of separatists is a manifestation of the writ of the state on the ground" after August 2019. "They have realised that violence or subversion is futile in the long run," he says. "The overwhelming impact of electoral politics on restive south Kashmir is a win for change of narrative and perception."

In the villages, many first-time voters are happy with the Jamaat's return to electoral politics, but others also ask who will take the blame for the past killings of mainstream party workers. Outside the small shrine of Kashmir's revered Sufi saint Sheikh-ul-Alam in Kulgam's Adjan village, a young voter scoffs at Reshi repeatedly stressing how he was an 'Indian citizen'. "He doesn't want us to vote for liars. But we want to ask, was the Jamaat lying to the people all this while? They were chanting '*Kashmir banega Pakistan*' earlier. Now that they think (Prime Minister) Modi is powerful, they are falling in line," he says. ■

VOTE FOR CHANGE

- **A dozen separatist leaders are contesting the assembly polls; they feel the old boycott policy was futile**
- **The LS poll saw 58.4% voter turnout, highest in 35 years. It's a key reason why parties are enthused**

By Rahul Noronha

Madrasas, or schools that chiefly impart Islamic learning, are under the scanner in Madhya Pradesh, with the state government's school education department conducting a probe into their functioning. There are two main issues that have prompted the move—the question of non-Muslim students studying in madrasas without the consent of their guardians, and the matter of non-existent students allegedly kept on the rolls in some madrasas so that they can keep receiving government aid. While the BJP regime claims that the move is aimed at making madrasas more efficient, madrasa owners claim that it seeks to weaken them and raise suspicion about their functioning in public.

The action against madrasas started after the National Commission for Protection of Child Rights wrote to the state government last year, asking them if Hindu children have been enrolled in madrasas—as was brought to its notice—against their parents' wishes. "There is no bar on Hindu children studying in a madrasa, but they have to secure parental/ guardian consent like all other students before joining," says an official of the MP Madrasa Board.

The August 16 state government directive asks district collectors to inspect all madrasas registered with the MP Madrasa Board and, besides parental consent for non-Muslim students, focus also on the infrastructure, student enrolment and teacher availability. It asks officials to scrutinise student records of madrasas and find out if they have been padded up with fictitious names just to receive annual government grants given to all registered madrasas. The order says a madrasa guilty of this would have its recognition cancelled. Some weeks ago, 56 madrasas in Sheopur district were found to be wanting on various counts of compliance and notices have